

that will inspire you to pursue a purpose in life beyond your own personal wish fulfillment, you should read *Herland* or *An Old-Fashioned Girl*.



When I was first learning how to be a spinster, my mentors were three straight African American women, ten or twenty years ahead of me, who had spent long years of their youth in a small, mostly white town in suburban New Jersey. All of them had lives full of friendship, faith, family, community, political purposefulness, significant caregiving responsibilities, dazzling professional success, and, occasionally or eventually, real romance. But they also had lives marked by the demographic reality of blackness in America. None of them had the standard story of most of their white peers: pair off in your twenties or thirties; marry; have kids. From these women I learned to measure singleness not in months but in years, or even decades. As one of them quipped when I asked about her love life when she was my age, "I know why the caged bird sings."

These women taught me to question my own entitled white-girl assumptions about relationships and marital status: that marriage (or spinsterhood) is a simple matter of figuring out what you want and waiting for it to happen, or making it happen. They taught me not to self-dramatize or presume, and not to project my own experiences onto others. I remember one of them telling me, clear-eyed and matter-of-fact, "If I'd met someone when I was younger and we'd had kids together, that would have been my life, and I would have

had those experiences. But I didn't, so this is my life instead, and now looking back it's hard to imagine it any other way." For them, marital status was less about chasing wishes or fulfilling a destiny and more about making something meaningful with the life you have.

My mentors taught me that friendships are family and friendships are love. One of them told me that even though she'd spent many years in romantic relationships, it was her friendships with women that first taught her about intimacy and caregiving. They taught me to think systemically, and to question the structural injustice that honors the commitments of couples and married people but fails to recognize the validity of other forms of family and the immense caregiving work done by daughters, sisters, aunts, and friends. Once I was assigned last place in a grad-student housing draw because I was single and the housing authorities were giving priority to couples because they might need more space. I was bummed out, but my mentor was incensed. "They don't know your life! Just because you don't have a boyfriend or girlfriend doesn't mean you're always home alone. Anyway you're all paying the same. You should be treated the same." In a way these women taught me a new kind of entitlement: one that insists on the value of my life and relationships, and resists all the ways, large and small, that lives are diminished by the dominance of the couple form.

There are urgent reasons why spinsters need to look beyond the self and resist the system. As Alcott's insistence on the ballot box suggests, insofar as the conversation about unmarried women remains a conversation about choice and individual temperament and not about politics, it is missing

something important. Even though the contingencies of when and whom I marry don't define my existence, marriage is still an important legal and social category with implications for many practical and symbolic aspects of adult life. Because in our culture, marriage is a choice, but it also isn't. It's a rom-com ending and a party with a cake, but it's also a systemic mechanism that separates the enfranchised from the disenfranchised, the included from the excluded.

And unfortunately, the momentous *Obergefell v. Hodges* Supreme Court decision remedies some of these injustices while shoring up others. In too many important ways, marriage and the couple form are still the legal and social prerequisites for the sharing of resources and lives, the care of the sick, the parenting of children. This arbitrary conflation of marriage with the commitments and responsibilities of adult life sometimes turns unmarried people into second-class citizens, while devaluing many necessary forms of love.

I'm glad gay marriage is now legal. But as a spinster who craves connection and community above all and who has found it outside of the standard couple form, I've come to realize that I owe an immeasurable debt to the intersecting groups of people who have historically been barred from the privileges of marriage by law and demography and have learned to create intimate lives apart from it. In other words, I'm indebted to queer people and to African Americans, and to all who have seen their loves and families treated as nonexistent or pathological, and who have had marriage used as a weapon against them or as a compulsory straight and narrow path to equality. These people are more than "awakeners": They have done the hard work of loving and world-making

in defiance of the powers that be, and all unmarried people continue to benefit from their centuries of emotional and material labor.

For years, queer people have made lives and loves without access to most legal protections or religious rituals. Now, in the age of legal gay marriage, many queer people are being forced to adopt the traditional form of marriage (regardless of whether it fits the shape of their lives) in order to access health benefits or shared custody, a prospect that is often less than liberating. Meanwhile, from the cruelty of slavery to the callous "marriage cure" of the George W. Bush administration, from the Moynihan Report to the million and a half "missing" black men, marriage has been made simultaneously compulsory and unattainable for millions of African Americans whose family formations and most cherished relationships are honored neither by American society nor the state. And there are so many others whom marriage fails to recognize or protect: all whose families are torn apart by citizenship status and national borders; all whose loves and commitments exceed the boundaries of the nuclear family norm.

The author of *Spinster* champions an individualistic kind of feminism, but she is apparently uninterested in reflecting on the politics of marriage as a system and the way its oppressiveness might prompt privileged people like herself to seek alliances with people she pushes to the margins: poor people, queer people, people of color. This marginalization is not an accident. Single black women feature as a kind of cautionary tale in the *Atlantic* article on which Bolick's book is based, but in *Spinster* she repeatedly makes the conscious decision to exclude them altogether. At one point she starts to compare

one of her “awakeners” to Billie Holiday, only to stop abruptly after a few sentences, informing her reader that it would be “specious” for her to attempt to include black women in her book, because they should have a (separate but equal?) spinster book of their own. Meanwhile, Bolick’s willfully oblivious defense of the absolute whiteness of her “awakeners” has infuriated every woman of color I know who has read it:

Not until I was driving through my blindingly white hometown did I realize that the only characteristics all five women had in common were a highly ambivalent relationship to the institution of marriage, the opportunity to articulate this ambivalence, and whiteness—each of which, arguably, was inextricable from the rest. During the period I was drawn to—primarily, the turn of the last century—vanishingly few women of color were given the privilege to write and publish and, therefore, speak across the decades.

If Bolick is interested in writing only about pale redheads, she should own this preference and not use words like “vanishing” to try to make it go away. Because the late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century period she writes about was in fact full of writing women of color with ambivalent relationships to the institution of marriage: Nella Larsen and Zora Neale Hurston are not exactly obscure writers, and they wouldn’t even have required Bolick to look beyond New York City. When Bolick says whiteness was an “inextricable” characteristic of women who wrote ambivalently about marriage, she is perpetuating racism, not describing it.

The truth is that Bolick didn’t need to do a deep archive dive to find out how women create full lives without being wives. She could have chosen to pay attention to the lives of women of varied classes and colors living in her own city right now. But Bolick’s spinster wish is not political. It is pretty and private and pristine and pale. And this is a problem. As Jessa Crispin has tweeted, “if the pretty people now get the word ‘spinster’ I am comfortable switching over to ‘hag.’”

“Hag” is a splendid word, but I don’t think we need to surrender “spinster.” We still need spinster. We need Connie Sun’s wry *How to Find Love: Lessons from an Old Maid* at *McSweeney’s*, and Ashley Boney’s bold “I’m a Single Black Girl and I Refuse to be Scared by the Statistics Saying I Will Never Get Married” in *xoJane*. We need the humane voice of Sara Eckel, who writes so wisely about midlife loneliness and love’s randomness, and the affectionate and much-missed spinster love of *The Toast*, and the passion of Emily Rapp Black’s tear-stained love letter to the spinsters who taught her about “Transformation and Transcendence: The Power of Female Friendship.” We need satire and protest and unapologetic in-your-face stigma and courage and unhinged adoration and matter-of-fact, no-nonsense happiness. We need fierce female loves.

I cling to the word “spinster” in the second decade of the twenty-first century because it serves as a challenge to the way our society still conflates coupledness with love, maturity, and citizenship, while seeing unmarried people as—to quote Justice Kennedy—“condemned to live in loneliness.” And, to borrow a phrase from second-wave historian Carroll Smith-Rosenberg, I cling to the word because it links me with

my spinster sisters throughout history in a shared “female world of love and ritual.” I cling to it and hold it close because, to riff on a refrain from Hilton Als, it’s the spinsters who made me.



It’s the spinsters who made me. Who made farm-share feasts with me for our family dinners and watched *Golden Girls* with me every night. Who sent me silver-framed photographs of us at a Houston diner, and glitter-framed photographs of us at Graceland, and magnet-backed photographs to put on my fridge of us sharing a bed at a Palm Springs hotel. Who talked with me for hours on the phone as we lay a thousand miles apart in bed in the dark until one of us finally fell asleep. Who asked me to help them choose their mother’s gravestone. Who told me about their abortions. Who bought me a dress for my yet-to-be-adopted daughter. Who made me the aunt of their one-eyed Chihuahua. Who sat next to me in church. Who swayed on the piano bench as they accompanied the gospel choir with a ring on every finger, playing from “sheet music” that was simply a piece of paper saying “Abundantly Blessed in F.” Who burned sage in my apartment and said blessings and jingled bells and burned small sticks of aromatic Panamanian wood to drive out the bad energy after my roommate’s psychotic break. Who came into money unexpectedly and paid off my \$65,000 student loans and changed my life forever. Who left me long, delirious voicemails on the happiest day of their life with their voice stretched almost to breaking with joy. Who sent me lilies on my birthday

(“It’s Heavenly to Be With You” in the language of flowers) and filled my Easter basket and stuffed my Christmas stocking and made me black-eyed peas on New Year’s for good luck. Who invited me over for cava in the garden or vinho verde on the deck. Who invited me to stay with them during a hurricane when my house was shaking. Who were my family and made me their family as they lived with metastatic cancer. Who called me “Lovely” and “Lady” and “Sweetie-pie” and “Dear.” Whom I called “Lovely” and “Lady” and “Sweetie-pie” and “Dear.” Who are my readers and editors and muses and collaborators and confidants. Who are my loves. Who know that, although in the eyes of the world and the law we are alone, we are not alone.



So often with spinster stories it is the endings that betray us—with their tall, handsome boyfriends who appear in the nick of time (as happens in *Spinster*), their well-tamed shrews and prettified tomboys, their inevitable weddings. Of course I finished the first draft of this essay while attending a glorious wedding in the Catskills on the very same weekend that Ireland voted to legalize gay marriage, and of course I finished the final draft on the weekend that SCOTUS followed suit. Of course I wept with joy when my glowing friend read her wedding vows in the dappled May sunshine and leaned against her new husband with utter trust, and I wept with gratitude when I read the tweets of all the Irish people who traveled #hometovote, and I rainbowed my Facebook profile picture along with everybody else. I could feel the tide-like tow of the

marriage plot and the ancient satisfactions of the Hollywood happy ending, and I was susceptible to conflicting surges of spinsterish and unspinsterish feeling. All of this is perfectly predictable and understandable—after all, I’ve written other essays about my love for straight men and wedding vows—but ambivalence is not where this essay is destined to end, because unrelenting spinster endings are too hard-won.

I’ll leave you instead with benedictions from three of my favorite spinster texts, each with a different spin on the spinster and her final fate. I don’t know what the future holds for me and the rest of my spinster sisterhood, but I know I would rejoice to have any of these as my epitaph.

Louisa May Alcott, *An Old-Fashioned Girl* (1869):

Lest any of my young readers who have honored Maud with their interest should suffer the pangs of unsatisfied curiosity as to her future, I will add for their benefit that she did not marry Will, but remained a busy, lively spinster all her days.

Bette Davis as Charlotte Vale in *Now, Voyager* (1942):

Don't let's ask for the moon. We have the stars.

Emily Nussbaum, “Difficult Women,” on a counterfactual version of *Sex and the City* in which Carrie does not marry (2013):

What if it were the story of a woman who lost herself in her thirties, who was changed by a poisonous, powerful love affair, and who emerged, finally, surrounded by her friends?